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Democracy Dies in Darkness

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Iran war, economy pull down Trump

President polls his highest disapproval mark, fueling GOP's midterm fears

BY SCOTT CLEMENT
AND DAN BALZ

Six months ahead of the November midterm elections, the Republican Party faces a deteriorating political climate, with Americans broadly dissatisfied with President Donald Trump's leadership on the Iran war and other key issues and an electorate in which Democrats are significantly more motivated to vote, according to a Washington Post-ABC News-Ipsos poll.

Trump's approval on economic issues, which were critical to his political comeback in 2024, has fallen since he launched the Iran war in late February.

Americans disapprove of his handling of the situation with Iran by 66 percent to 33 percent. His rating on the economy has declined by seven points, to 34 percent, as gas prices have spiked. His approval rating on inflation has fallen five points in that time to 27 percent and his lowest rating comes on perceptions of his handling of the general cost of living, with 23 percent approving vs. 76 percent disapproving.

Trump's overall approval now stands at 37 percent, largely the same as the 39 percent figure in February. But his disapproval has reached 62 percent, the highest of his two terms in office. Among Republicans, Trump's approval has held steady at 85 percent, but his ratings among Republican-leaning independents have reached a new low of 56 percent. His approval rating stands at 25 percent among independents overall.

Trump gets his best ratings for handling immigration at the U.S.-Mexico border (45 percent approval and 54 percent disapproval). His ratings for handling immigration overall are worse at 40 percent approving and 59 percent disapproving, hardly changed from 40 percent positive

SEE POLL ON A6



CAROLYN VAN HOUTEN/THE WASHINGTON POST

Trapped in a kill zone for 177 days, his wife's voice was his lifeline

The Ukrainian soldier is lying on a cold cement floor.

His beard is long, his hair matted. His fingers are broken. His teeth ache with rot. He is in the ruins of a factory in the northeastern city of Vovchansk. He is hungry and tired. His head throbs from untreated concussions.

The soldier strains to make out Russian voices on the other side of the wall. He hopes they cannot hear his friend moaning just a few yards away. He wants nothing more than to help him survive.

There is no escape. The phone networks and roads are destroyed. The fields are mined. The closest Ukrainian command point is miles away. Russian drones hunt anything that moves.

The soldier is named Roman Mongold. He is 38.

It is late August 2025 and he has been trapped since March, deep inside what Ukrainian troops call "the kill zone," a no-man's-land between the lines that reeks of death. His friend, Andrii, is 28 and dying from a treatable wound — a Russian

A Ukrainian soldier traded voice memos, aided by a commander, as he fought to survive

BY SIOBHÁN O'GRADY,
SERHII KOROLCHUK
AND ANASTACIA GALOUCHKA

Roman Mongold, pinned down by Russian forces for nearly six months, works on a training ground in November, imparting the knowledge he gained on the front line to other soldiers in the Kharkiv region of Ukraine.

bullet lodged in his right knee.

Roman hides in a corner. By radio, he asks his commander to drop more medicine from a drone. Each week, he also asks him to pass a message to his wife, Halyna.

Roman and Andrii were sent to Vovchansk, a small city on Ukraine's border with Russia, to try to hold off Russian forces advancing on Ukraine's second-largest city, Kharkiv, 45 miles to the southwest.

The men arrived separately — Roman in March 2025, Andrii in July. They came the same way, crossing the narrow Vovcha river that runs through Vovchansk and then spent days trying to reach frontline positions farther north in the city.

A fierce, ceaseless battle for this former industrial and rail hub has been underway since May 2024, when Russian troops launched a surprise attack. Slowly, Vovchansk has been destroyed.

Unlike other stretches of battlefield, where soldiers hold trenches and dugouts

SEE UKRAINE ON A12

U.S. to guide vessels in strait

TRUMP UNCLEAR ON TASK'S PARAMETERS

Iran's Hormuz closure has stranded ships for weeks

BY DAN DIAMOND
AND KAREN DEYOUNG

President Donald Trump said Sunday that the United States would soon begin guiding ships through the Strait of Hormuz, calling it a humanitarian gesture requested by other countries whose vessels, crews and supplies have been stuck for weeks.

"The Ship movement is merely meant to free up people, companies, and Countries that have done absolutely nothing wrong — They are victims of circumstance," Trump wrote on his Truth Social platform. He also wrote that his representatives have been having "very positive discussions" with Iranian leaders about formally ending the hostilities between the U.S. and Iran that have rattled the region.

Trump did not provide details about the plan, what actions the U.S. would undertake to facilitate the exit of ships or how many vessels are set to exit through the strait. It was not clear from his statement whether the U.S. would only provide ship captains information to guide them to safe routes through the strait or take more active measures.

The White House did not immediately respond to questions about the logistics and U.S. military risks.

The strait, a key waterway off the coast of Iran, has been closed to shipping, which has trapped oil, fertilizer and petroleum products in the Persian Gulf and driven up energy prices worldwide. An estimated 2,000 ships have been trapped since Iran closed the strait last month to any ships without its permission, and the U.S. announced its own blockade of all ships traveling to or from Iranian ports, causing a standoff

SEE IRAN ON A11

What's really ailing American politics?

Ten small-town strangers spanning the ideological spectrum came together on a surprising solution

BY CASEY PARKS

WASCO, ORE. — Steve Radcliffe knew, as he backed a Subaru hatchback up to the old Wasco Grade School, that his event might not draw even a single participant. The town had only 417 residents, and Radcliffe suspected a decent number would rather spend their Friday night at home or the local tavern than talk about what Radcliffe considered one of the country's thorniest issues.

But Radcliffe was the hopeful sort. He had traveled three days and 355 miles to discuss the urban-rural divide, and he refused to believe he'd spent \$1,800 of his own money for nothing. He pulled a tan cowboy hat low on his forehead, then he and a group of aging volunteers strode into the building.

Inside, they found a woman fussing over the right way to set up 10 plastic chairs in a room the size of a cafeteria. Jessica Richelderfer Wheeler told the out-of-towners she could trace

SEE DIVIDE ON A8



HELEN H. RICHARDSON/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Steve Radcliffe shakes hands with Wasco, Oregon, resident Margie Stovall before an April 24 town hall.

Mysterious organ could be key regulator of aging

Studies highlight thymus gland's potential role in longevity, battling cancer

BY CAROLYN Y. JOHNSON

For decades, a mysterious, two-lobed organ nestled behind the breastbone has been overlooked by most physicians, thought to be a largely useless lump for most of human life: the thymus.

The ancient Greeks posited this knob of tissue might be the seat of the soul. In the early 1960s, a Nobel laureate dismissed it as a mere graveyard for cells, "an evolutionary accident of no very great significance." Today, scientists know the thymus plays an essential role in setting up a functioning immune system in childhood, but then starts to rapidly shrink into obsolescence in puberty.

Now, a raft of research is

recasting the thymus from a bit player to a potent regulator of aging and immune health across the lifespan.

Studies highlight the crucial role it might play in longevity, as well as protecting against cancer, autoimmune disease and cardiovascular risk. The work has ignited interest in finding ways to rejuvenate the thymus, slow its decay and better understand its function.

"It was completely assumed the thymus would become irrelevant," said Hugo Aerts, director of the Artificial Intelligence in Medicine Program at Mass General Brigham. In studies published in Nature, Aerts and colleagues found that people with a healthier thymus were less likely to develop lung cancer or to die of heart disease — or any cause. They also responded better to cancer immunotherapy treatments.

Key questions remain: Is the thymus the driver of these improved health outcomes or an

SEE THYMUS ON A9

IN THE NEWS

Legal fight escalates A watchdog group asked a court to block the Trump administration from moving forward with plans that could shutter D.C.'s East Potomac Golf Links. C7

Correspondents' dinner A U.S. attorney said ballistic evidence shows that the alleged assailant shot at a Secret Service officer. A4

THE NATION

Two more Republican-controlled states took steps to redraw their congressional maps. A2
Rudy Giuliani, the ex-mayor of New York and a former Trump adviser, is hospitalized. A8

THE WORLD

Secretary of State Marco Rubio is planning to meet with Pope Leo XIV this week. A11
Two U.S. soldiers were reported missing during a multinational training exercise in Morocco. A11

THE ECONOMY

In a policy pivot, the Trump administration is welcoming imports that can bolster U.S. artificial intelligence infrastructure. A16
Big Tech firms that invest heavily in AI are cutting their workforces but have yet to rein in overall costs. A16

STYLE

The newly released "Devil Wears Prada" sequel is built to satisfy die-hard fans of the 2006 original. B1

SPORTS

Pitcher Daylen Lile, in his second year with the Nats, is better able to handle adversity. C1

THE REGION

For the members of an all-male book club in Maryland, reading has been a shared pleasure for 30 years. C7

HEALTH & SCIENCE

Advances in brain imaging offer new evidence for reevaluating the medical establishment's definition of ADHD. D1

BUSINESS NEWS.....A16
COMICS.....B4
OBITUARIES.....C10
OPINION PAGES.....A14
TELEVISION.....B6
WORLD NEWS.....A10

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